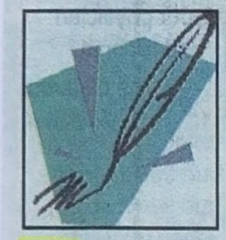
YOGA: You're Obviously Gonna Ache

I had laughed when the voice on the phone told me to wear as little as possible, but standing there with my fellow yoga students, I realized she had been serious. I stood in soccer shorts, nothing more, but I might as well have been wearing a ski suit at a bikini contest. Speedos aside, I was sorely (in every sense of the word) mistaken in my perception of yoga.

People's concept of yoga ranges widely, from athletics, exercise and physical therapy to ritual, philosophy and even art. A sign on the door told me that the word "yoj," or yoga, means "union" in Sanskrit, but as far as I was concerned, it translated into something along the lines of "groin pull" or "severe spinal injury."



Jeff Foss

Voices

"Welcome to Bikram's Yoga College. Jimmy Barkan should be here any minute. No shoes in the yoga studio." The girl at the sign-in desk was young, which was very reassuring, and I thanked her for not charging me for the water bottle and towel I neglected to bring. Before changing, I decided to take a quick look around the lobby. It was nothing like the monastery I expected.

In fact, the place felt very much like an athletic club, and a ritzy one at that. If it weren't for the faint scent of incense, I'd expect to find a weight room or hot tub somewhere. My eyes settled on the Polaroid pictures on the wall and grew wide. They depicted bodies of all shapes and sizes, and all ages for that matter, twisted and contorted into disturbing pretzel-like shapes.

Jimmy Barkan entered the room not long after I had laid down my towel and mat in the back corner of the mirrored studio. He certainly wasn't the holy man I had expected. Healthy and super tan, he looked to be about 45 years old . . . wearing nothing but a turquoise Speedo. After a brief introduction, Mr. Barkan turned the attention to the class.

"How many of you have been doing yoga at least five years?"

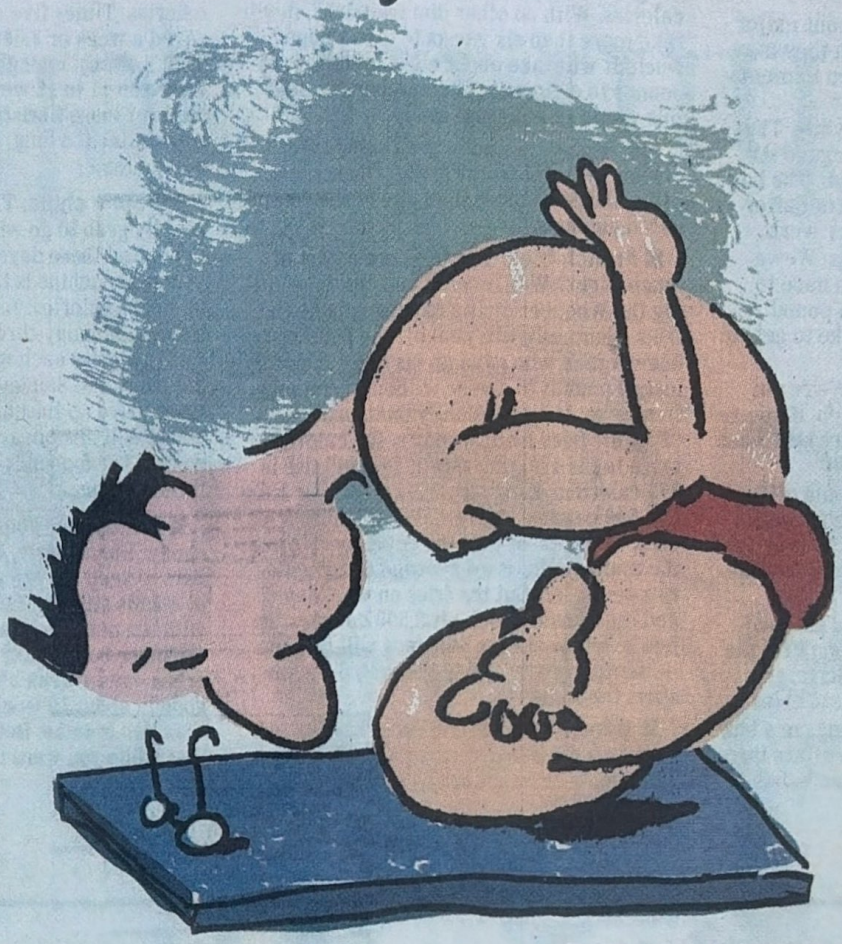
To my amazement, roughly half the class raised their hands. I was in trouble.

"What about three years? Two years?"

I saw a vicious pattern developing as hand after hand shot up. When the smoke cleared, the closest student in terms of experience had still been doing yoga for over six months. Mr. Barkan singled me out cheerfully.

"A real beginner, eh?" I nodded sheepishly. "OK. We'll take it real easy. Just go at your own pace and keep within your own physical limits. Everyone ready . . . "

We began with some breathing exercises called Pranayama. Thirty lungs inhaled and exhaled all around me, in perfect synchronization, and suddenly the room itself was one tremendous resting organism. It was well over 100 degrees in the studio, unique to this specific type of yoga, to mimic the conditions in Calcutta and increase flexibility. Maybe they should have jacked it up a few degrees for me; my tendons felt like suspension bridge cables as we began the first stretches.



The Denver Post / **Cindy Enright**

After just a few minutes I was literally dripping. The triangle was tough, the eagle was harder and the half-moon an absolute killer, but I caught myself half-smiling. Less than a week before I had somehow tweaked my lower back jumping off a diving board, but now the pain had vanished. Mr. Barkan walked around the room, occasionally pushing some part of someone's body in place. He reached me as I tiptoed the border between holding the position and snapping my own spine. "You're really, really tight, Jeff. Wow. You need to come in here more often." Constructive criticism I suppose.

After 90 grueling minutes we had come full circle, and we lay on our towels with our feet together and our palms up, doing Pranayama breathing again. I felt great, ready to run a marathon or max out on bench presses or . . . take a shower. People began to rise and disappear, some stopping to ask how my first day of yoga was. "Painful," I replied. On the way out the door I caught Mr. Barkan.

"Yoga is a way of life for me," he explained with more than a hint of enthusiasm. "It nourishes the soul and quiets the stress in my life. It represents a mental, physical and spiritual union. And it keeps me in good shape."

Joanna Harrow, the young woman at the desk who advised me of the appropriate attire over the phone, said yoga gives her clarity. "I'm not a spiritual person," she said, "but yoga gives a sense of myself and my body that I haven't been able to find anywhere else."

With my back pain gone and my mind at ease, I departed the studio. One thing about yoga is certain: You can get as much or as little out of it as you want.

It can be very spiritual but doesn't have to be that way at all. It can be something you do six days a weeks for the next 20 years, like Mr. Barkan, or something you try once and get a kick out of. Maybe that's part of the beauty of it. I never expected to "see the light" and become hooked on yoga after having taken the class, and frankly, I didn't. However, the experience definitely opened my eyes.

If 90 minutes can do more for my back than six painkillers, I'm impressed . . . but don't expect me to sport the Speedo.

Jeff Foss lives in Colorado Springs.